Before You Give In

What is this pleasure promising — and do I have grounds to agree?

READING

Epictetus, *Enchiridion* 34 and *Discourses* 4.12.1–5. Epictetus advises delay and considering pleasure's aftermath. His account of attention also includes play and song. We apply these ideas to examining a compelling promise; enjoyment can still be a reasonable choice.

BEFORE THE MEETING

Announce on your Substack with the reading links. Invite an ordinary example: scrolling, shopping, or another episode. No private habit needs to be disclosed.

Open · 10	Read · 10	Practice · 20	Discuss · 40	Close · 10
Welcome; no confessions required	Aloud, together	Test the promise of one more episode	The questions below	One takeaway each

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. When an urge says "one more," what exactly is it asking you to believe?
2. What would a brief delay let you examine that the urge leaves out?
3. How can you consider the aftermath without assuming all enjoyment leads to regret?
4. What captures your attention repeatedly, and how does that shape what seems worth choosing?
5. When might a limit chosen in advance help judgment — and when should you reconsider it?

PRACTICE THIS MONTH

Examine the promise. Pause in one recurring temptation, name the promised benefit, and consider the choice now and afterward. Accept, revise, or decline on grounds you can explain; an advance limit can help you remember them. Pleasure alone does not settle it.

FACILITATOR'S MOVE

"What is the claim?" Find the judgment inside "I need this now." Passing on pleasure is not automatically progress; more careful examination is.

NOTES